CHAPTER 8 · DEEP DIVE · A HOUSE DIVIDED

Appomattox

How the war ended — not with vengeance, but with mercy. April 9, 1865.

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

How the war ended — not with vengeance, but with mercy. April 9, 1865.

When you have finally defeated an enemy who nearly destroyed your nation, how should you treat them?

The End of the Road

APRIL 1865

After abandoning Petersburg, Lee's starving, shrinking army fled west, hoping to escape and fight on. Grant's forces cut them off at every turn. Within a week, Lee was trapped near a small Virginia village called Appomattox Court House.

His army was down to fewer than 30,000 exhausted men, surrounded and out of supplies. On April 9, 1865, Lee agreed to meet Grant to surrender.

The McLean House, Appomattox Court House, Virginia — scene of Lee's surrender — photograph, 1865, public domain (Library of Congress).

The House Where the War Ended

APPOMATTOX COURT HOUSE, VA.

The two generals met in the parlor of Wilmer McLean's home. By a strange twist, McLean had moved to Appomattox to escape the war after the first battle of Bull Run was fought on his earlier farm.

The McLean House, Appomattox Court House, Virginia — scene of Lee's surrender — photograph, 1865, public domain (Library of Congress).

Generous in Victory

THE TERMS

Grant could have demanded a humiliating, punishing surrender. Instead, following Lincoln's spirit of “malice toward none,” he offered generous terms. Confederate soldiers would be paroled and sent home, not imprisoned. Officers could keep their sidearms; men who owned horses could keep them for spring plowing.

When Union troops began to celebrate, Grant ordered them to stop — “The war is over,” he said; “the rebels are our countrymen again.” He even sent rations to feed Lee's hungry men.

Lt. Gen. Ulysses S. Grant and Gen. Robert E. Lee — photographs, 1864–65, public domain (Library of Congress).

Grant and Lee

THE TWO COMMANDERS

The victor and the vanquished. Grant, in a mud-spattered field coat, had hounded Lee's army to exhaustion; Lee, in his finest dress uniform, came to give it up. Their meeting set the tone for the peace.

Lt. Gen. Ulysses S. Grant and Gen. Robert E. Lee — photographs, 1864–65, public domain (Library of Congress).

“Their Hearts … Must Have Been Sad”

APRIL 9, 1865

Later prints imagined the quiet dignity of the meeting — Lee in a crisp dress uniform, Grant in a mud-spattered field coat. Two men ending four years of war with a handshake.

“The Surrender of General Lee, April 9, 1865” — lithograph, public domain (Library of Congress).

ULYSSES S. GRANT, ON SEEING LEE SURRENDER

I felt … sad and depressed at the downfall of a foe who had fought so long and valiantly, and had suffered so much for a cause, though that cause was, I believe, one of the worst for which a people ever fought.

See It From Both Sides

YOUR TURN

You'll read how Grant and others remembered Appomattox and practice point of view — understanding why the victors chose mercy, and what that choice was meant to accomplish.